

# AITA for dismissing those who anchor their views of AI based on hearing the concerns regarding energy/water/carbon?

Posted by u/Immediate-Run-3579 • 0 points • 21 comments

I'm aware this may just be an echo chamber, but I need to ask.

My wife has made it clear recently that she is anti-AI. To the point where I could say: "Hey, guess what, I fed my research in to a LLM and with a few prompts it's helped me find the cure for cancer" (I know this is absurd, but run with it.) As soon as I mention AI I know it won't be long until I hear her eyes roll back in to her skull. I challenged her on this the other day and her entire argument was "the environmental impact." I clapped back by asking her how much of an environmental impact do streaming services have, to which she didn't have an answer. I've since looked, using ChatGPT, and it is substantially more, to the point that has me wondering why nobody is throwing shade at Netflix & Disney for wasting water etc like they do AI. Anyway, AITA here for pointing out the cognitive dissonance here that a streaming=good / AI=bad; because nobody told me the impact + I don't want to feel bad binge watching Bake Off mindset is ridiculous?

## Comments

u/Fine\_Manufacturer368 • 1 points • 2025-07-13 21:09 UTC

Anyone who's lived near an area where some "cloud data center" was installed has an extremely helpful experience to read about. The TL;DR you utility needs become secondary to whatever company purchased the government in that area. I'm not looking forward to suddenly lower water pressure or brown outs in my area.

u/ban\_circumvention\_ • 1 points • 2025-07-11 11:34 UTC

Why are you "clapping back" at your wife? Are you a celebrity being featured in a TMZ article from 2011?

u/banedlol • 1 points • 2025-07-11 11:23 UTC

The way I see it, actual breakthrough AGI could help crack things like fusion, cure diseases etc, so it's worthwhile.

IMO fusion is the only viable solution to climate change. Near-infinite energy would be the next industrial revolution.

u/Character\_Car\_5871 • 1 points • 2025-07-11 00:09 UTC

As someone who is also married I can tell you that you are the asshole not for pointing out the cognitive dissonance, but because you're insisting that you are correct and by doing so you both get to feel bad about enjoying things.

u/According\_Ad7895 • 1 points • 2025-07-10 15:53 UTC

When the government and corporations stop literally fucking the earth for oil I'll consider limiting my use.

This problem needs to be tackled with the biggest offenders first if we want to have any impact at all.

u/CustardFromCthulhu • 1 points • 2025-07-10 03:33 UTC

There have been a lot of nonsense stats about AI resource usage. The oft-quoted liters of water per query is silly, for starters - how much is just cooling water cycling through cooling loops? They don't pour the water over the servers and then it vanishes into a black hole or something.

u/CortexAndCurses • 2 points • 2025-07-10 01:53 UTC

AI is only using more of the SAME energy from dirty sources as anything else, right? So maybe the anger should be directed at the power companies for dirty energy and not just those consuming more of it.

It's absolutely a concern as far as power consumption, but that's mainly because we aren't using clean power.

u/Eugregoria • 2 points • 2025-07-10 01:15 UTC

In essence I do agree, everything about modern life is already destroying the planet anyway and that's never stopped us before.

But eh, I have to question the comparison to streaming. AI is taking so much energy it's actually affecting stability of the grid and potentially bringing back nuclear power. Microsoft bought the closed Three Mile Island nuclear plant recently, planning to use the nuclear power for AI. Where we're going to get power for all this AI is actually something of a logistical crisis that's changing how we think about power generation. We didn't see anything like this for Netflix, and we've had it for ages.

Maybe it's that AI, unlike streaming, is exponentially growing. Maybe it's the integration into \*everything\*. Idk. But it does feel a little disingenuous to say streaming is "worse" than AI in terms of power consumption/environmental impact. We didn't see streaming make these kinds of waves.

As for the comparison to factory farming, eh, that's a complex topic, and I'm not really in favor of factory farming, even beyond environmental impact and animal welfare there are serious concerns about effects on human health (runoff, antibiotic resistance, worker safety inside the farms). But factory farming makes \*food\*. Whether we need animal products to live is something you could debate hotly for a while (technically, humans can survive on a vegan diet with modern supplementation, however, actually meeting the full nutritional needs of everyone, especially the poor, without animal products, is a far more complex issue--animal products \*are\* nutritious in a way it's harder to replicate with a vegan diet--not impossible, just \*harder\*) and food is also deeply and innately tied with culture, feelings of scarcity, sense of wellbeing, etc. Eliminating factory farming could mean meat still exists, as an expensive gourmet product only those of a certain socioeconomic class have access to, which is something I don't really like the implications of from a class justice perspective. As with most complex social problems, more equitable solutions could be found, but they'd require a lot of political will, money,

and social investment that doesn't exist, and some more drastic reorderings of how we do society (e.g. non-factory, less environmentally damaging, more healthy farms might need strong subsidies). \*Most\* social problems could be solved if we actually cared to devote the social and economic resources into solving them, the problem is that we don't.

Not really looking to argue with vegans on this one lmao, spare me.

But food and nutrition are such a deep-rooted issue in human society, I don't think that can be fairly compared to a technology that didn't even exist a few years ago and that no current adults were raised with.

I still think Pandora's box is already open here, and "should we use AI?" isn't even a question anymore--we're \*gonna\* use it, there's no "we just lose interest in AI" scenario that's realistic. Given that, I don't think scorning it is actually a good idea. Ironically, the people who hate AI the most are the most likely to be duped by it. Part of why I can spot AI-generated text is because I actually talk to chatbots so I know what they sound like. People who don't talk to chatbots are far more at risk of thinking they're talking to a human when they're not. Looking at images you \*know\* to be AI-generated and generating some yourself will teach you a lot more about how to detect AI images, and what the strengths and limitations of GenAI are.

**u/Bannon9k** • 1 points • 2025-07-10 00:53 UTC

Cars didn't eliminate horses, there's just less of them. This ain't Disneyland, it's life ...adapt or die

**u/ResidentHistory632** • 1 points • 2025-07-09 23:42 UTC

I had a friend tell me "writing a 100 word email with ChatGPT takes the same electricity as half an iPhone charge!!!" It's the sort of thing that sort of sounds a lot if you're not thinking but I looked up the numbers and it worked out as about 5 seconds of heating my home in January, or about 1 m of a flight on a passenger jet. I'm amazed at how people latch onto these alarmist "statistics". Especially someone like my friend who has a science PhD, albeit one of the less numerate sciences.

**u/Vaeon** • 3 points • 2025-07-10 00:14 UTC

Most people use statistics the same way a drunkard uses a lamp post: Not for illumination, but for support. -- Benjamin Disraeli.

**u/velocirapture-** • 5 points • 2025-07-09 22:09 UTC

I always argue it takes 1,675 gallons for one pound of beef, and I've been vegetarian for 15 years, so I've earned whatever water is used to cool servers with my AI usage.

**u/sandoreclegane** • 3 points • 2025-07-09 20:31 UTC

aye, shes just scared, its normal...this stuff is gonna change everything...anyone can pick and choose their reason for hate, i've found that listening to the concerns, asking questions, and engaging empathetically I've been able to move the needle on my own wife and start showing her some of the benefits.

**u/Kathilliana** • 14 points • 2025-07-09 20:25 UTC

You can have one pound of beef or 600 hours of ChatGPT.

Everything is expensive.

**u/velocirapture-** • 5 points • 2025-07-09 22:10 UTC

That's exactly the metric I use!

**u/AnnaRift** • 10 points • 2025-07-09 20:06 UTC

you're not the asshole for pointing out the double standard. People just pick and choose what to hate without actually digging into the facts.

**u/DanteInferior** • 1 points • 2025-07-13 01:26 UTC

At least streaming services offer entertainment. LLMs are fucking useless.

**u/joyofresh** • 5 points • 2025-07-09 19:59 UTC

The impact of substantial and growing, but data centers in total are not a huge percentage of global emissions. Ai is a bit scary because it's such a huge present even though it's only been around (in its current explosive form) for a few years, but it's nowhere near cars or meat or concrete or steel.

Streaming is way down there. You can offset a lot of usage by eating some tofu. Yes, it all matters, it all adds up, but its closer to half a percent of all emissions, not 10% if all emissions. Half a percent for a new tech is massive, actually, but its not meat or cars.

**u/Vaeon** • 8 points • 2025-07-09 19:56 UTC

No, you are not.

Does your wife complain about the environmental impact of:

1. NASCAR
2. Professional Sports (Football, Soccer, Baseball, etc)
3. Music Industry
4. Film industry
5. Tourism
6. Factory farming

I could go on but I don't think I need to.

**u/Kathilliana** • 5 points • 2025-07-09 20:25 UTC

I agree completely.

**u/Accomplished\_Bag4838** • -4 points • 2025-07-09 20:14 UTC

All of those have less significantly less emissions. Not really sure what your point is.

She can dislike something because of its impact without you randomly bringing up something as unrelated and irrelevant to her as NASCAR.

**u/Rudybus** • 6 points • 2025-07-09 22:51 UTC

Factory farms pump out about 14% of total greenhouse emissions. Tourism is about 8%.

I've seen an estimate of LLM usage being literally 0.01% of global emissions.

In fact for productive work, getting an LLM do to it emits [less carbon](<http://Reconciling the contrasting narratives on the environmental impact of large language models | Scientific Reports https://share.google/iKo13i9VUE7GBTtfh>) than getting a human to do it.

**u/freezeontheway** • 3 points • 2025-07-09 19:54 UTC

e/AITAH

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-07-09 19:52 UTC

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u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-07-09 19:52 UTC

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